

ATTITUDES

Social Psychology has been more affected by passing fads and fashions than almost any other major branch of the discipline. Yet, through all the changes in briefly 'hot' research topics, one concept has maintained its commanding position at the core of this sub-discipline. It is the concept of 'social attitudes', more often simply referred to as 'attitudes'. Psychological social psychology's first modern textbook¹ already devotes a section to this topic (F.H. Allport, 1924), and seventy years later, it is reported that during the most recent twenty-year period over 34,000 published studies addressed attitudes in some way (Kraus, 1995).

Popular and convenient as the notion of 'attitudes' may have turned out to be, it is nevertheless a rather recent addition to the conceptual inventory of psychology. Although the *word* 'attitude' occurs in some psychological literature dating back to the first two decades of the twentieth century, the *category* of 'social attitudes' (note the plural) only makes its decisive entry into social psychological discourse in the period beginning at the end of World War I. The history of modern usage might well be regarded as beginning at this point. However, because earlier technical uses of 'attitude' throw an interesting light on more recent usage, it is worth taking a brief look at this bit of 'pre-history'.

An unpromising beginning

Technical, as distinct from everyday, uses of 'attitude' first occur in discourse about art, especially visual art and the theatre. Both of these art forms were very much concerned with making inner states visible, presenting outwardly visible forms as the *expression* of an inner reality. The *posture* of a figure depicted by an actor, a painter or a sculptor was never understood merely as a physical disposition of bodily parts in space but always carried a meaning due to its expressive function. The 'attitude' of the figure was the visible arrangement of its parts into a meaningful pattern, as in 'an attitude of waiting', or of devotion, or of nonchalance, for example. It should be noted that here there is no question of a causal link between an inner and an outer aspect. Rather, the 'attitude' of the figure refers to an inherent unity of inner and outer

which endows certain physical appearances with expressive meaning (Hoff, 1990).

But once 'attitude' had been given a home in the arts, it acquired connotations of artificiality which were probably decisive for its subsequent history. For the attitudes depicted on stage and on canvas were of course deliberate creations and not spontaneous expressions. Certainly, by the nineteenth century people could be accused of 'striking an attitude', though this usage was clearly parasitic on the earlier understanding of attitude as 'the unstudied expression of action or passion' (*Oxford English Dictionary*, 1989 I: 771).

Attitudes were rescued from the taint of artificiality by their appearance in the biological discourse of the late nineteenth century. No small role was played in this by the appearance of Charles Darwin's *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals* in 1872. Although Darwin did not explicitly define 'attitude' as a technical term, he did make quite frequent use of it as referring to the pattern of motor activity which constitutes the overt expression of an emotion. Not only did this establish 'attitude' as a category of nature rather than of art, it also suggested deep biological roots. No longer was the term limited to humans in its application. Rather, humans displayed attitudes because of their biological heritage. Darwin's use established 'attitude' as a category of natural phenomena that clearly fell within the domain of a biologically oriented psychology. Accordingly, we find 'emotional attitudes' being addressed by the Chicago functionalists, Dewey (1894) and Angell (1904). The link between attitude and the relatively specific topic of emotional expression was however becoming fragile. James Mark Baldwin was already devoting considerable attention to so-called 'motor attitudes', a much broader category that included all kinds of habitual response in addition to emotional expression (Baldwin, 1894).

The notion of 'motor attitudes' was soon to acquire a certain aura of scientific respectability through the work of Sir Charles Sherrington, the British neurophysiologist, who spoke of attitudes in the context of reflex postural adjustments on the part of animal organisms (Sherrington, 1961). In this case, attitude had been shorn of its mental, experiential, aspect and could be employed as a purely physiological category. This made the term acceptable to behaviourists like J.B. Watson (1919) who wanted to establish Psychology as a purely biological science concerned with the reactive movements of organisms.

While the biological and physiological appropriation of attitude showed an increasingly physicalistic slant, its everyday use seems to have taken the opposite tack of taking it to refer to purely mental events. The phrase 'attitude of mind' is to be found in quite a number of nineteenth-century works, including that of Herbert Spencer (1871). However, this phrase is used colloquially and never takes on scientific pretensions. Alexander Bain, the major defender of nineteenth-century associationism, takes a small step in this direction when he speaks of

'the forces of the mind' getting into 'a set track or attitude' (Bain, 1868: 158). But 'attitude' never becomes a significant category of nineteenth-century psychology in any way comparable to 'attention' or 'habit'.

The fact that American psychological texts of the early 1920s (Pillsbury, 1921; Warren, 1922; Woodworth, 1921) generally do contain some treatment of attitude as a psychological topic is due, primarily, to the physiological grounding of the term, as discussed earlier, and secondarily, to a peculiar accident of translation that had occurred a few years earlier. At the beginning of the twentieth century, a number of investigators at the University of Würzburg in Germany began a series of systematic introspective studies on the conscious processes that could be observed while one was engaged in trying to solve a task set by an experimenter. Traditionally, conscious experiences were categorized as either ideational or volitional (a division which has its roots in an Aristotelian distinction), but the Würzburg investigators believed they could detect a third variety of conscious event, to which they gave the name of *Bewusstseinslagen* (Mayer and Orth, 1901). The German language allows one to combine words to form compound words with a new meaning. So in this case we have *Bewusstsein*, which means consciousness, and the plural of *Lage*, which means position. Thus, *Bewusstseinslagen* refers to the positions assumed by consciousness under different conditions. But 'positions of consciousness' is an awkward and not very illuminating term in English. Perhaps there is a more effective translation?

E.B. Titchener, the major representative of an introspective psychology of consciousness in the US, thought so. He decided that *Bewusstseinslage* meant 'something like posture or attitude of consciousness' (Titchener, 1909: 100), ignoring the fact that both posture and attitude have quite straightforward German equivalents (*Haltung* and *Einstellung*) which had *not* been used by the Würzburg investigators. No matter, Titchener's 'something like' was good enough to establish 'conscious attitudes' as an important category for English-language introspective psychology.

Interestingly, the category survived the demise of this branch of the discipline which followed within little more than a decade. That survival is presumably due to the possibility of fusing a physicalistic meaning, expressed in the term 'motor attitudes', with a metaphorical extension of that meaning to what were now called 'conscious attitudes'. The mind was now supposed to be capable of taking up a mental posture towards some presented content, much as an animal organism takes up an emotional posture *vis-à-vis* a predator or rival. For Margaret Washburn, who had studied with Titchener, the literal interpretation still predominated. She claimed that all cognitive events were accompanied by motor reactions. Even though these might be very slight, they were crucially implicated in the maintenance of 'conscious attitudes' (Washburn, 1916). As the existence of these hypothetical motor reactions proved to be unconfirmable by means of objective observation, later

authors paid less and less attention to them, relying more on a metaphorical extension of the concept of posture from the physical to the mental level.

One can identify three features of the early history of the attitude concept that were particularly important for later developments.

First, there was a gradual transformation of 'attitude' from a category whose members consisted of observables to a purely *dispositional* concept involving inferred entities. Certainly, the earlier 'expressive' attitudes referred to things that were visually observed: the inclination of the head in a painted figure, the gait and bearing of a dramatic actor. This remains true of Darwin's expressive emotional attitudes and Sherrington's postural reflexes. In these cases there is however also an implication that certain attitudes are based on the hard wiring of the organism. American psychologists took up the notion that attitudes involved a disposition to react in specific ways, though they tended to reject the inborn nature of such dispositions. As stimulus-response psychology became fashionable during the 1920s, there was an increasingly obvious need for dispositional concepts that could account for the extreme variability of stimulus-response relationships. John Dewey, who had become aware of the limitations of stimulus-response psychology two decades earlier (Dewey, 1896), favoured 'habit' as the major dispositional concept and used 'attitude' as a synonym for it (Dewey, 1922).

Broad though Dewey's conception of attitude was, it appears almost pedantic next to the promiscuous use of the term by psychologists around 1930. 'Attitude' was now in general currency, as an all-purpose dispositional term that no longer needed to be qualified by adjectives like 'motor' or 'conscious'. Instead, it was used indiscriminately as a synonym for virtually any other psychological dispositional term in current use. For example, a 1932 article with the general title 'Theories and measurement of attitudes' is entirely concerned with the assessment of what was then called 'character', i.e. 'personality' in modern parlance (Sherman, 1932). A review article with much the same title, published two years earlier, declares that 'it must be confessed that most writers use such terms as attitude, trait, opinion, wish, interest, disposition, desire, bias, preference, prejudice, will, sentiment, motive, objective, goal, idea, ideal, emotion, and even instinct and reflex, loosely, indefinitely, and often interchangeably' (Bain, 1930: 359). The common denominator of all these terms is said to be their reference to 'acquired and conditioned action-patterns that motivate human social behavior', where 'conditioned action-pattern' is used as a synonym for 'drive'. Not only had 'attitude' lost any precise empirical reference, it had been shorn of any distinctive conceptual characteristics as well.

The second feature to be noted in connection with the early twentieth-century development of the attitude concept concerns the nature of the link between the 'inner' and the 'outer'. Both in classical and in latter-day usage 'attitude' was deployed so as to establish a link between

something visible on the surface and something going on under the surface. Classically, that link was characterized as 'expression'. Particular facial expressions or bodily postures 'expressed' particular emotions or feeling states. The link of inner and outer through expression definitely did not imply that the inner *caused* the outer. Actors were usually advised not to attempt experiencing the emotions which their actions on stage depicted. Visible actions and postures were assumed to have an intrinsic inner meaning which they made manifest to the observer.

By the time we get to twentieth-century psychology the idea of an expressive link between inner and outer has been lost.² Instead, we get two entirely distinct domains constituted, on the one hand, by so-called 'motor attitudes', which are purely physical events without intrinsic meaning, and on the other hand, 'conscious attitudes', which have no connection with overt action. In the behaviourist realignment that is characteristic of the post-World War II period, motor attitudes are submerged in the all-inclusive category of 'behaviour', and conscious attitudes are replaced by a mishmash of dispositions, as illustrated above. The link between the two domains is causal. Dispositions like motives, attitudes and personality characteristics are conceived of as causing 'behaviour', much as a gas under pressure might cause the movement of a cylinder.

That conception brings us to a third important feature in the development of 'attitude' as a psychological concept, a development that had its basis in certain characteristics of psychological research practice. Psychological experiments with human subjects are of course social situations. Psychological data are the products of a social interaction between the participants in such situations (Danziger, 1990a). Typically, an experimenter presents a subject with certain instructions as well as specific questions, to which a subject responds, verbally or otherwise. Traditionally, however, the data gathered by these means were never interpreted as products of a social interaction; at best, the social aspects of psychological experimentation were regarded as a source of error, to be controlled as far as possible. What makes a psychological experiment a psychological experiment is the unwritten rule that the conduct of the experimental subject is to be interpreted as a response to impersonal, asocial 'stimuli', mediated by psychological processes inside the subject. Working within this taken for granted framework psychologists naturally developed an insatiable appetite for all manner of intra-subjective states that would account for the wide variety of behaviour encountered under experimental conditions.

We can see this imperative at work among the investigators who came up with the idea of what Titchener called 'conscious attitudes'. As was the custom at the time, these investigators served in the role of experimental subject for each other. In the experimental situation, the individual who happened to be taking the role of experimenter would

set the person in the subject role various tasks, such as defining a given word, expressing a personal preference between two famous men whose names were presented to the subject, giving free associations to pictures that were shown, answering questions like 'Does monism really mean the negation of personality?'³ Now, we may ask ourselves, what would constitute an adequate account or explanation of how the subjects in these experiments arrived at their solutions to these tasks? To the introspective psychologists of the Würzburg School the answer to such a question could be taken for granted: one had to identify the mental processes or events that intervened between the presentation of the task and the solution offered by the subject. Accordingly, the experimental subjects were required to supply introspective reports on their mental processes while carrying out such tasks. It was then that the previously mentioned *Bewusstseinslagen* or 'conscious attitudes' turned up. Vague though the reports on them were, they had to be accepted as the answer to the implicit question motivating these investigations: how to account for subjects' response to the experimental situation in terms of their observable mental processes? The possibility of an alternative account that took the experimental subject to be a social agent making the best of a tricky social situation would not have been available to these investigators.

An alternative account was however soon to appear, though it was no more open to the social realities of psychological experimentation than the Würzburg account had been. Having become quite pessimistic about the likely practical yield from the practice of introspection, American psychologists dropped the (Wundtian) requirement that psychological processes had to be *observed* to occur before they could be postulated as mediating between experimental task and response. It now became acceptable simply to hypothesize the existence of such processes located within the individual. No longer did one rely on experimental subjects to identify these processes; instead, it was up to the experimenter to stipulate what they were. The result was total conceptual anarchy. So in the literature of the 1920s the number of different definitions of attitude exceeds the number of investigators working in the field, for some of them used more than one definition at various times. Only one unwritten rule was universally respected: whatever this thing was, it was real and lurked somewhere within the individual. Breaking this rule would have meant abandoning the common understanding of what psychological investigation was all about.

That attitude research grew into a flourishing little industry in spite of this unpromising start was due to two factors which we must examine next. The first of these impinged on the discipline from outside in the form of unprecedented public interest in what were popularly known as 'social attitudes'. The second factor was internal to the discipline and involved the proposal of a credible solution to the task of 'attitude measurement'.

How attitudes became 'social'

Although attitudes were not unknown to Psychology before the 1920s, their theoretical status was that of auxiliary concepts rather than that of a core concept capable of integrating an entire field of research. Titchener's 'conscious attitudes' came close, but when the entire enterprise of 'systematic introspective psychology', never of much importance in the North American context, was abandoned altogether in the years after World War I, the term 'attitude' would seem to have had a very limited psychological future, at best. Indeed, at least one influential writer suggested it be discarded (Symonds, 1927).

What saved 'attitude' from oblivion was its novel coupling with the attribute 'social'. In psychological usage the term 'attitude' had always been qualified in some way or other; in addition to conscious attitudes there were emotional and motor attitudes, as we have seen. Then, in the 1920s, a few psychologists, notably the brothers Floyd and Gordon Allport, began coupling 'attitude' with 'social' and opened an altogether new chapter in the psychology of attitudes. The topic of 'social attitudes' made it possible for psychologists to lay claim to an area of popular concern that had previously been the preserve of sociologists. On the surface, however, there was little to connect the notion of 'social attitudes' with the attitude concepts of the older psychology. In Floyd Allport's social psychological text (Allport, 1924), the first in the psychological literature to pay attention to 'social attitudes', that topic had indeed been treated entirely separately from the psychology of attitudes, discussed in more traditional terms. As late as 1939, a general review of the literature appeared in two parts, one devoted to the 'nature and development' of attitudes, the other to 'social attitudes' (Nelson, 1939).

The category of 'social attitudes' was not based on any conceptual development within Psychology but constituted an importation from outside the discipline. Six years prior to the appearance of Floyd Allport's text the prominent sociologist, W.I. Thomas, had given considerable theoretical significance to the concept in his classic study of Polish immigrants, which he co-authored with the young Polish sociologist, Florian Znaniecki (Thomas and Znaniecki, 1918). In the lengthy 'methodological note' which formed the introduction to that volume, attitudes had been given the role of a core concept in a discipline which scarcely existed at the time, namely, social psychology. This was clearly distinguished from both sociology, which was concerned with the principles of social organization, and psychology, which was focused on the states of individuals. Social psychology had the task of dealing with the evident interdependence of these two levels, and for this purpose it required its own distinguishing concepts. The category of 'attitude' was deployed to satisfy this requirement.

But the term was now given a meaning which ran counter to earlier psychological usage. Certainly, attitudes involved conscious processes, but to treat them simply *as* facts of individual consciousness was to abstract from their social nature and turn them into the objects of a science of asocial individuals. Thomas clearly recognized the role of psychological research practice in this process of abstraction:

Concretely speaking, any method of research which takes the individual as a distinct entity and isolates him from his social environment, whether in order to determine by introspective analysis the content and form of his conscious processes, or in order to investigate the organic facts accompanying these processes, or, finally, in order to study experimentally his behavior as reaction to certain stimuli, finds necessarily only psychical, physical or biological facts essentially and indissolubly connected with the individual as a psychical, physical, or generally biological reality. (Thomas and Znaniecki, 1918: 26)

Individual psychology necessarily isolates attitude as 'an object in itself' and studies it in relation to other states of the same individual. Social psychology, however, would treat attitude 'as primarily manifested in its reference to the social world and taken first of all in connection with some social value. . . . The psychological process remains always fundamentally a *state of somebody*; the attitude remains always fundamentally an attitude *toward something*' (Thomas and Znaniecki, 1918: 22–23; original italics). The social psychological attitude concept then was to be deployed to study the co-ordination, the interdependence, of individual consciousness and cultural values.

The kind of social psychology envisaged by Floyd Allport was however very different from what Thomas and Znaniecki had had in mind. It was to be a *psychological*, not a *sociological*, social psychology. To Allport, this meant a reduction of all social phenomena to the behaviour of individuals. There was nothing in human social life, except *separate individuals* (the italics are Allport's) and their reaction to each other as external stimuli (Allport, 1924: 3–6). In a later work, the distinctly ideological basis of Allport's position emerged more explicitly (Allport, 1933). Assigning some kind of reality to social institutions was to indulge in dangerous collectivistic illusions. Only individuals and the sum total of their reactions to each other were real, and psychology was the science to study them (Graumann, 1986; Paicheler, 1988). For Allport, there was a gratifying convergence of a general political agenda and the specific disciplinary project which he represented. His psychological social psychology was to be 'experimental', which meant that, rather than studying humans in institutional or cultural contexts, as the social sciences did, the basic data would consist of the responses of separate individuals to artificially constructed situations (Danziger, 1992a).

When F.H. Allport, and the psychologists who followed along his path, used the category 'social attitudes', therefore, they did not mean

the subjective side of collective values in the manner of sociologists like W.I. Thomas. Collective or cultural values had no existence apart from the reactions and dispositions of separate individuals. Attitudes were simply individual attributes, to be studied in terms of their intra-psychic organization, their relation to other individual attributes like intelligence and personality traits, and their susceptibility to controlled manipulation. As Gordon Allport put it, 'the political nature of man is indistinguishable from his personality as a whole' (Allport, 1929: 238). Whether individual psychologists were aware of this or not, this sort of belief was itself political and also congruent with political values that were deeply entrenched in American culture.

The excursion of American psychologists into the field of 'social attitudes' took place at a time when this term had acquired considerable currency in public discourse. In 1929, President Hoover appointed a high level Committee to investigate 'social trends in the United States'. This resulted in a number of reports on such matters as population trends, rural social trends, and 'political, social and economic activities of women', but, significantly, it also included a report on 'changing social attitudes and interests' (Hart, 1933). The category of 'social attitudes' had come to be widely accepted as providing a framework for discussing a broad range of social concerns. The report of the Hoover Commission was mainly concerned with such topics as 'declining approval of organized Christianity', 'antagonism toward traditional sex attitudes', 'declining approval of religious sanctions for sex conduct', 'prohibition sentiment', 'radicalism', 'labor relations', and 'international attitudes' (Hart, 1933). Other areas of social concern for which the concept of 'social attitudes' provided an interpretive umbrella were social stratification, delinquency, and immigration (Young, 1931), as well as the influence of propaganda (Chen, 1933) and of motion pictures (Thurstone, 1930). The areas of race relations (Katz and Braly, 1933) and of industrial management (Uhrbrock, 1933) were not far behind. Quite early, the term 'social attitudes' had been used as a synonym for 'opinions', especially political opinions. That made it easy for research on attitudes to merge with existing concerns about political radicalism and the conviction that it had a psychological basis (see Vetter, 1930 for examples). By the mid-1930s 'attitude' had become an all-purpose tool for tracing social problems to their supposed source in individual minds.

The need for such a tool had been anticipated a decade earlier by the highly respected writer and journalist, Walter Lippmann. His widely read *Public Opinion* (Lippmann, 1922) gave expression to current concerns about the magical effectiveness of propaganda and the manipulation of voters by emphasizing the subjective aspects of social behaviour. What people do, even what they think and feel, is determined by what Lippmann variously referred to as 'interior representations of the world' and 'pseudo-environments' (Lippmann, 1922: 27), or,

more famously, as 'fictions', 'pictures in our heads', and 'stereotypes'. Expressing a faith in scientific expertise that was characteristic of his age, Lippmann suggested that his analysis showed the need for a body of social scientists who would systematically study public opinion with the purpose of advising policy makers. Arguments such as these would provide effective support for the increasing tendency, in American social science, to ascribe a causal role to desirable and undesirable 'social attitudes'.

The attachment of the term 'social' to the older category of 'attitude' signalled its new deployment as the quasi-scientific equivalent of Lippmann's 'pictures in our heads'. American social scientists gladly responded to the call for expertise sounded by publicists like Lippmann. Whereas the use of the term 'attitude' had been unusual in sociological, psychological and social psychological textbooks prior to 1920, it occurs in half of the texts published between 1920 and 1925; between 1925 and the beginning of the 1930s that figure rises to 80 per cent (Droba, 1933). The surging popularity of 'attitude' was not accompanied by any consensus on what exactly this term referred to. There were many attempted definitions of attitude in circulation. One participant observed: "'Attitude" is a term which has currently come into very general use among sociologists, social psychologists, and writers on education. It is a good example of an ill-defined, or undefined, concept used in a loose, pseudo-scientific manner. The result is a confusion many times confounded' (Bain, 1928: 942). Similarly, a psychological dictionary of that time warned its readers that 'attitude' was a 'loosely used term' (English, 1928). There was little to distinguish the use of the term in the empirical literature of the social sciences from its use in everyday lay discourse. D. Fleming, author of an extensive historical study of the attitude concept, speaks of 'a rampant cross-infection that spread both ways, from popular usage to scientific and back again' (Fleming, 1967: 360).

To a psychologist critic like William McDougall, whose ideas hailed from another age and another culture, the whole situation seemed absurd:

American social psychologists and sociologists have recently produced a voluminous literature concerning what they call 'social attitudes'; the term is used to cover a multitude of facts of many kinds, including almost every variety of opinion and belief and all the abstract qualities of personality . . . as well as the units of affective organization. . . . I cannot see how progress in social psychology can be made without a more discriminating terminology. (McDougall, 1933: 219)

However, McDougall's gloomy prognosis turned out to be quite wrong, at least on external criteria of 'progress'. There were several reasons for this, one of which was the development of a technology of 'attitude measurement', which will be discussed in the next section. Another reason was that the lack of conceptual rigour was actually an advantage

if one wanted to advance bold claims for the broad applicability of the attitude concept. For psychologists, it provided a basis for giving a new social relevance to their field. Much of academic psychology had remained quite remote from everyday concerns, but the topic of social attitudes created a new branch of the subject which was relevant for an extraordinary range of immediate public concerns: 'The whims of fashion, the success and the failure of propaganda, the swing of public opinion, the depredations of a mob, and a change in moral standards, are alike unintelligible excepting in terms of the attitudes of individual men and women', wrote Gordon Allport in an authoritative review that was in part a reply to McDougall (Allport, 1935: 806).

In order to succeed, such a claim would have to rely on a certain convergence in the implicit meaning of 'attitude' for the specialist and for the lay public. A core of implicit meaning would also provide a basis for the experts' belief that, in spite of the differences in their formal definitions of 'attitude', they were still talking about the same thing. In spite of surface disagreement, a number of widely shared assumptions characterized the discursive deployment of 'attitude'.

The first, and simplest, of these assumptions touched directly on the quarrel between McDougall and American social scientists. McDougall was an instinct theorist of the old school, who accounted for quite a number of what were now regarded as attitudinal phenomena by invoking the category of 'sentiment'. But McDougall's sentiments were rooted in the instincts, and this was now anathema to American social scientists. One thing on which they did broadly agree was the *acquired* nature of attitudes. Whatever else they might be, they were essentially learned and therefore infinitely modifiable. In the ongoing debate about the plasticity of human nature, the users of the attitude concept were not to be found among the innatists.

A second assumption, almost universally shared by the psychologist friends of 'attitude', has already been discussed in the context of Floyd Allport's launch of a psychological social psychology. For psychologists, attitudes were strictly *individual* attributes, where individuals were understood as separate entities and not as the parts of a social or cultural collectivity. In psychological usage there was no place for Thomas' original conception of attitudes as the subjective side of culture, as necessarily linked to social values. Psychological individuals could come to hold attitudes in common through having been exposed to similar learning experiences, but on this view culture remained an external influence and collectivities were a 'fiction'. An echo of the battle against the sociologists can still be detected in Gordon Allport's insistence that a range of social phenomena could only be made intelligible in terms of 'the attitudes of *individual* men and women' (see above). One reason why the psychological version of the attitude concept proved more enduring than the sociological one is its perfect fit with the traditional beliefs of an individualistic culture.

Thirdly, it is worth noting that psychological definitions of attitude tended to agree in defining it as a '*state of readiness*' of some kind (G.W. Allport, 1935). In other words, 'attitude' is more than simply a dispositional term. It is taken as referring to an actually existing state of affairs inside the individual. Because attitudes always relate to specific objects or situations, an individual necessarily has many attitudes inhabiting him or her, each one having an identifiable and distinct existence. Once formed, they are carried around by the individual on a more or less long term basis. And they are states that have effects. Attitudes have *causal* properties, 'exerting a directive or dynamic influence upon the individual's response to all objects and situations with which it is related,' as Allport (1935: 810) puts it. It is quite possible to think of attitudes as simply a form of attribution that has its place in the discursive practices that people use to make sense of each other's conduct. The use of the attitude concept in Psychology, however, always implied much more than that. Underpinning its use, there is a whole metaphysic of unobservable but nevertheless real and distinct entities that push and direct the person from within. It is this image that gives plausibility to the idea that attitudes can be *measured*.

Before we consider this crucial development, there is one more taken for granted feature of the psychological attitude concept that should be mentioned. When discussing the change from the original, expressive use of 'attitude' to its psychological use, we noted that this involved a splitting of the older unity between an inner state and its outward expression. The disjunction between the inner and the outer aspects of human action reached its most extreme form in early twentieth-century psychology, spawning, first, a 'systematic' introspective psychology of consciousness, and then, in almost immediate reaction, a radical behaviourism that equated action with observable movement. Whatever the stance of individual psychologists towards the more extravagant claims of radical behaviourism, the adoption of the category of 'behaviour' as the centrepiece of a generally accepted disciplinary language entailed the acceptance of a dualistic metaphysic that distinguished sharply between observable, external 'behaviour' and its inferred, internal, causes. When the concept of 'attitude' was assimilated within this framework it came to refer to some inner state that was, by definition, distinct from what was seen on the outside. This provided a basis for endless research and discussion about the degree to which attitude and behaviour were correlated (Kraus, 1995).⁴

Although there was some sociological participation in this debate, sociologically oriented theorists tended to reject the extreme dualism implied in the psychological usage of key terms, thus introducing a further difference in the psychological and the sociological understanding of 'attitude'. Sociologists often spoke of 'acts' or 'action', rather than 'behaviour', emphasizing that the 'inner' intentional or dispositional aspects of an act were part of the act and not to be arbitrarily

distinguished from its 'outer', or 'behavioural' aspects (Faris, 1928; Mead, 1934). From this point of view, attitudes could be seen, not simply as intra-individual states, but as part of an inter-individual reality involving individuals 'taking the attitudes of the others' (Mead, 1924-25). This difference in the psychological and the sociological understanding of 'attitude' is intimately tied up with a difference in the meaning of 'social'. In the psychological literature, attitudes were 'social' insofar as they referred to individual reactions to 'social stimuli'. These were simply a sub-category of stimuli in general and were interpreted in terms of a biological metaphor of organisms responding to features of the physical environment. For many sociologists, however, this was to miss the essential character of the 'social'. Social actions, like those of co-operation, competition or exchange, were only intelligible as actions involving several individuals, each playing a part in the completion of the whole action. From this point of view, it was possible to speak of a 'conversation of attitudes' (Mead, 1912), a notion that made little sense in terms of a purely psychological conception of attitude.

The smell of success: attitudes are measured

Had the attitude concept continued simply as an elastic vehicle for psychological claims to have something to say about social issues, it would have commanded little respect in the long run. It might even have been 'exorcized as a metaphysical ghost, pale and wanly qualitative' (Fleming, 1967: 340). What saved the concept's scientific respectability was the development of a technology for *measuring* attitudes. This occurred towards the end of the 1920s and provided the basis for virtually all future research on attitudes, at least within the discipline of Psychology. Agreement on the appropriate technology made it possible to ignore fundamental questions about the nature of attitudes and concentrate on such empirical questions as could be asked and answered within the framework established by this technology. It was clear to many of the participants that this created a situation quite analogous to that in the field of intelligence testing, where the successful application of a technology had not been impeded by theoretical disagreement (G.W. Allport, 1935: 828).

Attitude measurement greatly strengthened claims for the social utility of attitude research. In fact, the realization that this would be the case helped to launch the enterprise of attitude measurement in the first place. By 1925, there had been attempts by prominent figures, both in Psychology and in Sociology, to develop a plausible way of measuring attitudes. The sociologist, E.S. Bogardus, had come up with the pseudo-metrical notion of 'social distance' that he tried to measure by means of questions about the respondents' willingness or unwillingness to admit members of another group to various degrees of social closeness, e.g. as

marriage partners, neighbours or fellow citizens (Bogardus, 1925). In the same year, Floyd Allport had also submitted a claim to have developed a method of measuring attitudes (Allport and Hartman, 1925). He was very clear about the motivation for such an undertaking:

One of our most important tasks in social psychology is the development of scales and techniques for studying national and racial attitudes, and for measuring allegiance – or hostility – to institutional fictions and stereotypes of nation, race and class. (Allport, 1932: 223)

Such goals did not simply represent the personal ambitions of one or two social scientists, but were part of a widely shared project that provided for the rationalization of educational and administrative programmes by means of precise measurement and calculation of their likely effects. In the US, such programmes have long been seen as part of a 'cult of efficiency' (Callahan, 1962) that began to affect ever larger areas of social life during the first part of the twentieth century. More generally, the phenomenon can be seen as part of a pervasive modern trend that enlists the human sciences in the task of making individuals more predictable, calculable and manageable (Rose, 1988).⁵

An influential text by P.M. Symonds, devoted to the application of psychological knowledge, provides a good example of this trend. Symonds starts with the following proposition:

Control of nature has been particularly facilitated by the invention of instruments of measurement. Similarly, the control of human conduct and education depends on the development of more exact methods of describing human conduct. The exact description of human conduct can be rendered most efficient when it is reduced to a form of measurement, for then small differences are most accurately portrayed and small differences most accurately noted. (Symonds, 1931: v)

Symonds identifies four areas which present 'the more pressing problems in the control of human relations' (p. 8): crime, insanity, vocational competence, and 'diagnosis of citizenship' (p. 11). The last area is largely concerned with character education and the inculcation of 'certain attitudes towards vital social issues'. From this point of view, Symonds welcomes the development of 'measures' of social attitudes which had just taken place. Such techniques would enable one to ensure that programmes for changing wrong into right attitudes could be monitored to make them more efficient. The big chance to put this into practice did not occur until a decade later, with America's entry into World War II, but the social promise of attitude measurement was apparent from the beginning.

But those who were most convinced of the benefits of attitude measurement on general, ideological, grounds did not necessarily have the technical sophistication to successfully carry through such an undertaking. The person who took the crucial steps in codifying attitude

measurement did not at first know what he was doing. This was L.L. Thurstone, an engineer by training, who had made the switch to Psychology early in his career. Teaching psychophysical methods at the University of Chicago, he looked around for applications that might prove more interesting for his students than the classical example of comparing lifted weights. Instead of weights, he presented his students with pairs of offences, asking them to indicate which of the two they regarded as more serious, and pairs of nationalities, where his students had to say which one they would prefer to associate with (Thurstone, 1952: 306–307). He soon realized that he had not been the first to extend psychophysical methods to ‘stimuli’ that were not physical. J.M. Cattell, one of the pioneers of modern American psychology, had used variants of such procedures to ‘measure’ the eminence of scientists, and others had attempted measurements of literary merit and of the estimated excellence of children’s handwriting and of children’s drawings. There was, by this time, nothing startling in extending the idea of measurement from the special area of psychophysics to the much broader realm of social judgement. By his own account, Thurstone was no social psychologist, but when he heard about the social psychological interest in finding a way of measuring attitudes, he seems to have decided that that was what his classroom exercises were:

Our work on attitudes was started when I had some correspondence with Floyd Allport about the appraisal of political opinions, and there was discussion here at that time about the concept of social distance which had been introduced by Bogardus. It was in such a setting that I speculated about the possible use of the new psychophysical toys. I wrote a paper entitled ‘Attitudes can be measured’. (Thurstone, 1952: 310)

How did Thurstone propose to make good on this claim? Certainly not by giving some crudely behaviouristic meaning to the term ‘attitude’. No, he was fully committed to the psychological imperative of seeing attitudes as inferred entities that existed within the individual below the surface of observable behaviour. Therefore, he needed to assume a close connection between these invisible entities and some observable signs that would reliably indicate their presence. Potentially, this opened up an enormous range of possibilities. For example, Thomas and Znaniecki (1918), in the work which made ‘attitude’ a concept in the social sciences, used textual passages in private letters as the empirical basis for inferring attitudes. Others (e.g. Hart, 1933) were using the content of magazine articles as an indication of attitudes. But Thurstone could not even consider such possibilities because they did not lend themselves to the application of his ‘psychophysical toys’.

It was Floyd Allport’s foray into attitude research that provided Thurstone with the empirical format he needed. In an earlier study, Allport and Hartman (1925) had written out sets of statements that represented various opinions on a number of political issues such as

Prohibition – a hot topic at the time. For example, the statement: 'Prohibition is correct in principle and although it cannot be strictly enforced, should nevertheless be retained', and the statement: 'Though prohibition is good in principle, it cannot be enforced, and therefore is actually doing more harm than good', were both included in a 'scale' of thirteen statements reflecting opinions about Prohibition. This scale was presented to student subjects who had to indicate which one statement most closely represented their own opinion about Prohibition. The technique of obtaining individuals' agreement or disagreement with statements on a list presented to them by a stranger had previously been used on a large scale in marketing research and to some extent in political polling (Converse, 1987). There was no sharp boundary between the practical employment of social judgement methods in advertising research and their use by psychologists like J.M. Cattell (Kuna, 1979). By the late 1920s these procedures had become part of the taken for granted social practices of American social life and the consumer culture. No one would have questioned that it was 'opinions' which these practices revealed.

But the relation of 'attitudes' to opinions uncovered in this way was somewhat more problematical. On the one hand, there was a marked tendency among psychologists to treat attitudes and opinions as synonymous (Bain, 1928). On the other hand, there were those who made a distinction between surface opinions, which had a more specific quality, and underlying attitudes which were of a more general nature. Thurstone sided with the second group. His distinction was between attitude, defined as 'the sum total of a man's inclinations and feelings, prejudice or bias, preconceived notions, ideas, fears, threats, and convictions about any specified topic' (Thurstone, 1928: 531), and opinion, defined as 'a verbal expression of attitude'. He proposed to 'use opinions as the means for measuring attitudes' (p. 532). Two stipulations, basic to the entire project of attitude measurement, appear here. First, that opinions be held to provide an index of intra-individual attributes, called attitudes. This assumption establishes a claim by psychologists to provide a scientific basis for otherwise low level opinion research. Secondly, it is stipulated that attitudes are to be measured by their verbal expression as opinions. This was quite arbitrary, as Thurstone seems to have recognized, for one could just as easily have said that a person's attitudes are revealed only in their actions and not in their merely verbal opinions. However, Thurstone's preference did help to give a scientific aura to the widespread use of the cheap and quick method of collecting responses to opinion statements. Any hope that social psychology would recover from what one reviewer referred to as 'questionnaire disease' (Bain, 1930) was now gone.

But the crucial assumption underlying the notion of attitude measurement is yet to come. As we have seen, Thurstone did not shrink from

assigning complexity to attitudes. However, that complexity was far beyond the reach of measurement. A simplification was necessary. So Thurstone introduced a distinction between a person's attitude in the psychological sense and something about that attitude which could be measured. The latter was called the 'attitude variable', for 'the very idea of measurement implies a linear continuum of some sort such as length, price, volume, weight, age' (Thurstone, 1928: 534). The attitude variable had to be described in such a way 'that one can speak of it in terms of "more" and "less"' (p. 536). Measurement, therefore, would substitute for something psychological and complex something else that was defined by its variation along one dimension, usually a position on a scale of being more or less pro or anti a given issue, like Prohibition or immigration restriction.

In the case of more complex issues more than one dimension might have to be invoked, but that would not affect the principle of reducing all forms of qualitative complexity to independently defined linear dimensions. As was recognized quite early, this entailed breaking down a complex state of affairs and measuring it in fragments. In the words of Gordon Allport: 'The price one must pay for bi-polarity and quantification in such cases is, of course, extreme, and often absurd *elementarism*' (Allport, 1935: 820; original italics). Other social psychologists were just as sceptical about the trade-off involved in the technology of attitude measurement. The most important textbook of the 1930s pointed to the danger that attitudes reduced to a linear scale would become 'like the victims of Procrustes' (Murphy et al., 1937: 897); in other words, mutilated to fit into a pre-constructed frame.

This did not stop the onward march of attitude measurement. The coming of the New Deal with its ambitious social programmes had increased the appetite of state agencies for polling techniques that went beyond the requirements of marketing research and election forecasts. Rensis Likert, a student of Thurstone's and employee of the US Department of Agriculture, devised a somewhat simplified version of attitude measurement that was much less cumbersome and time consuming than Thurstone's original methodology. In this form attitude measurement quickly caught on, both in academic and in field settings. Accepted procedure had cemented a conceptual link between underlying attitudes and the expressed opinions by means of which attitudes could be measured. The enormous popular success of opinion polling during the 1930s (Gallup and Rae, 1940) certainly did not hurt the prospects of research into attitudes, because it was easy to see the latter as providing the basic science counterpart to the more practically oriented opinion research.

But what really put attitude research on the map as a significant psychological industry was the practical use to which it was put in World War II. The US War Department established an 'Information and Education Division', staffed to a significant extent by social scientists

who already had a commitment to the attitude concept and its practical definition by the current measurement technology. Large scale studies of military morale, as well as the effects of propaganda and of various organizational factors, were conducted by means of this technology, the results being published after the war in the monumental multi-volume *Studies in Social Psychology in World War II* (Stouffer et al., 1949–50). A similar approach was only slightly less pervasive in large scale studies of civilian morale (Allport and Veltfort, 1943; Schmeidler and Allport, 1944) conducted at the time. In the words of one historian: 'the measurement of soldiers' and civilians' attitudes in the Second War corresponded to the measurement of recruits' intelligence in the First War as the consecration under fire of new psychological techniques for handling masses of men' (Fleming, 1967: 345). Just as intelligence testing had become the firmly institutionalized defining practice for the category of intelligence after World War I, so attitude measurement, or scaling, became the institutionalized defining practice for the category of 'attitude' after World War II.

Conceptually, the ground had been prepared for this development by Thurstone's analogy between psychophysical judgement and judgement applied to verbal statements having a social target. In his original argument, Thurstone still relied on an analogy between the comparison of two physical objects on a physical dimension like weight and the comparison of two opinion statements on a dimension of pro or anti some issue like Prohibition. In Likert's simplified method this analogy was no longer needed, as long as the results obtained by this method correlated statistically with the results obtained by Thurstone's method. The assumptions built into the claim that attitudes could be measured by these means thus sank ever further from view. What emerged was a technology to be applied quite unproblematically.

As in the case of intelligence, it was the technology that henceforth defined the practical employment of the concept. There might still be differences among investigators regarding the form of words used to define 'attitude', but these differences were of little importance compared to the emerging consensus about the way in which attitudes were to be investigated in practice. Research on attitudes now meant getting agree/disagree responses, usually from groups of students, to opinion statements that intercorrelated sufficiently to form what was called a 'scale'. The use of several, statistically linked, opinion statements distinguished attitude 'scaling' from opinion polling which generally worked with single questions but took pains to construct really representative samples of some real life population. Academic attitude research never bothered about this kind of sampling, because it was not concerned with the social distribution of opinions but with supposedly universal attributes of the hypothetical entities underlying surface opinions. The distinction between opinions and attitudes came to be based on a conceptual and practical division between the social content of opinion

statements and certain formal properties that could be constructed statistically.

That construction, however, depended on yet another implicit assumption, which also went back to Thurstone's original foray into attitude measurement. All measurement, even physical measurement, has to deal with the existence of variability. A few physical observations are routinely discarded as being due to human error. In psychological measurement the problem of variability is more pervasive, so that, from its beginnings, it had to rely on statistical means to extract the 'true' value of a parameter from a distribution of variable judgements (Fechner, 1966). In classical psychophysics such sets of judgements were always drawn from the same individual. However, when Thurstone applied the psychophysical analogy to attitude measurement, he quietly pooled judgements from several individuals, and this procedure became part of the generalized practice of attitude scaling. What was not recognized was that such a procedure produces a construct that is inter-individual, rather than intra-individual. If, like the psychological attitude researchers, one interprets this construct as representing an intra-individual entity, one makes the (implicit) assumption that the individuals whose responses have been pooled share the same cognitive representation of social stimuli (Jaspars and Fraser, 1984), i.e., that opinion statements are as unambiguous and as little in need of interpretation as physical stimuli, for example the heaviness of weights. This assumption is surely quite wrong. Worse still, one cannot assess the degree to which it is wrong without stepping outside the framework of conventional attitude measurement. As long as one remains within this framework, therefore, one can never know to what extent one's data are the result of variable inter-subject agreement on the meaning of the items constituting one's scale.⁶

This was not a significant source of concern for most investigators in the field of attitude research, however, because they were content to live with an 'operational' definition of attitude. Attitudes were whatever it was that attitude scales measured, just as intelligence was whatever intelligence tests measured. The question of the meaning of such measures was not often addressed.

A multiplicity of attitudes vs. an ideology?

It was in the aftermath of World War II that some concern about the meaning of social attitudes did emerge. This was a direct response to the horrors that Nazism had recently visited upon the world, horrors that seemed to be the product of crazed minds. Yet it was known that Nazism had had widespread popular support and might find a fertile soil elsewhere. What kind of mind, what kind of subjectivity, might prove hospitable to this virus?

Social scientists from Germany, who had themselves been targets of Nazi hate, had had to ask this question somewhat earlier in a different context. During the final years of the Weimar Republic in Germany, with the threat of a Nazi takeover on the horizon, associates of the Frankfurt Institute for Social Research had concerned themselves with the social outlook of groups in Germany, particularly workers. Much of this work was theoretical, but at least one major empirical investigation issued from this concern, Erich Fromm's study of *The Working Class in Weimar Germany* (Fromm, 1984). Here, responses to mostly open-ended questions were obtained from a considerable number of subjects and analysed qualitatively as well as quantitatively. In an American context this would have been regarded as a study of social attitudes, but the German investigators thought of it as a contribution to the theory of how objective social conditions, social consciousness and individual character interrelated.

Towards the end of World War II the Frankfurt tradition of social research briefly impinged on American attitude research because of the availability of exiled scholars previously associated with the Frankfurt Institute. The most significant result of this collaboration appeared in 1950 in the form of a lengthy research monograph known as *The Authoritarian Personality* (Adorno et al., 1950), a work which was an extraordinary amalgam of American technology and German theorizing. On the one hand, there was copious use of attitude scales, but on the other hand, some of the questions to which the study addressed itself and some of the interpretive categories with which it operated were European imports. In the present context, the most significant feature of the work is its pervasive reliance on the category of 'ideology'. Two of the five parts of the study are said to be about 'ideology', a concept which was almost unknown in the older American attitude research – and which was to disappear again from American social psychology a few years later.

Whereas the category of 'social attitudes' was a recent American construction, the concept of 'ideology' had a fairly long tradition of European social thought behind it. By 1945, social attitudes had been successfully claimed by the discipline of Psychology as purely individual attributes, whereas 'ideology' remained an essentially socio-political category that applied to individuals only by virtue of their membership of particular social groups. The attempt to marry the two notions was thus problematic from the start.

But the attitude-ideology dissonance involved two further contradictions which are worth mentioning here because of what they tell us about the nature of the attitude concept. First, the most common understanding of 'ideology' was based on a fundamental distinction between forms of social consciousness that were adequate to objective social conditions and forms that were not. The latter usually represented the kind of systematic falsification and distortion of the truth that was

referred to by the term 'ideology'. By contrast, the psychological understanding of 'social attitudes' did not involve any reference to their 'truth' in representing social reality. Attitudes were essentially individual valuations, but the valuations were those of the individuals to whom attitudes were attributed, not the valuations of those who did the attributing. Whereas the category 'ideology' carried clear moral connotations and expressed a social commitment on the part of those who employed it, 'social attitudes' had become part of the morally neutral language of a 'behavioural science' that simply registered facts without presuming to take a stand on them. The investigators of *The Authoritarian Personality* were therefore attempting to mix two disparate ways of doing social science, a morally and politically neutral way for which physical science was the model, and a socially engaged way whose commitments were built into its language. This unnatural mixture seems to have been a product of the times and the subject matter of the study: Fascism and virulent racism. These were not 'issues' like Prohibition or 'sexual freedom on campus', but matters of life and death. At that point the morally neutral language of attitudes no longer proved adequate. Later on, as social psychology increasingly turned its back on questions of a deeply political nature, nothing beyond the attitude concept was required to handle its limited range of concerns.

The second aspect of the contrast between attitudes and ideologies relates to a feature of the ideology concept that has not yet been mentioned. In English the term 'ideology' is sometimes used as the equivalent of the German *Weltanschauung*, or world view. Now, while a *Weltanschauung* may be intrinsically political, that is not necessarily the case. One might refer to an aesthetic or artistic world view, for example. What is being highlighted here is not so much the socio-political dimension as the internal coherence, the structural unity, of a set of views. Certainly, when the authors of *The Authoritarian Personality* referred to 'ethnocentric ideology', or 'religious ideology', for example, that is largely what they meant. Here the term 'ideology' is introduced in order to do justice to the observation that various opinions and attitudes typically go together, not only statistically, but also meaningfully. In other words, attitudes on specific issues are seen as having a place and a function in some higher order of subjective life, a world view or 'ideology'. Analysing extreme anti-Semitism, Adorno (Adorno et al., 1950: 619) writes: 'Charging the Jews with all existing evils seems to penetrate the darkness of reality like a searchlight and to allow for quick and all-comprising orientation.' Here anti-Semitism is not just an attitude among other attitudes, it is an essential feature of a world view; it has become an ideology.

This kind of analysis alerts us to the fact that the traditional use of the attitude concept implied a particular way of representing social consciousness. Attitude measurement, as we have seen, involved a layered

conception of social consciousness by its distinction between surface opinion, expressed in specific opinion statements, and underlying attitude, measured by a scale composed of such statements. But that is as far as the layering went. There was no layer of social consciousness that was deeper or more comprehensive than the layer made up of specific attitudes. These often correlated statistically, but insofar as that observation was seen as requiring an explanation at all, the explanation was sought in the realm of personal constitution. The concept of ideology, on the other hand, introduced a further layer of social consciousness that accounted for the coherence (and therefore the statistical correlation) among attitudes. On this view, specific social attitudes were not separate entities but intimately and meaningfully interconnected parts of a larger whole, ultimately traceable to certain social conditions.⁷ In that case, the attitudes isolated by the common scaling methods would be essentially artefacts that may actually mislead us in our attempt to understand social consciousness. If one pursues this line of analysis, then the deployment of the concept of social attitudes in twentieth-century social psychology can itself be characterized as ideological, and this time in the quasi-political sense of 'ideological'. What would be involved would be a systematic distortion or falsification of the true nature of social consciousness.

However, there is another possibility. Perhaps the model of social consciousness implied by the social psychological attitude concept is peculiarly appropriate under certain historical and social conditions, specifically the conditions in which this concept emerged. If the structure of social consciousness is itself historically variable, then it may not always take on the form of ideology. That there have been times and places marked by an ideological way of relating to the world is surely undeniable. But there may be circumstances which favour a breakdown of ideology and result in less integrated forms of social consciousness. Perhaps then the social psychology of social attitudes is but one aspect of a more pervasive phenomenon akin to what is sometimes referred to as 'the end of ideology' (Bell, 1960). Unfortunately, such a neat explanation has to face the complicating presence of one particular ideology, that of liberal democracy. The political institutions promoted by this ideology actually presuppose that social consciousness takes a form similar to the image underlying the social attitude model. Where people are polarized by deep ideological divisions, conflicts are not decided by majority vote but by more drastic means. The institutions of liberal democracy can only function properly in the hands of individuals who implicitly believe that human minds reflect the pluralism of these institutions. The image of many individuals taking different positions on a multiplicity of attitude scales accords perfectly with an idealized version of the institutions of liberal democracy.

What is presupposed in that version is exactly what was presupposed in the notion that attitudes could be measured, namely, that individuals

take positions on the *same* set of attitudinal dimensions. That ultimately reduces all inter-individual differences to quantitative differences, to differences of degree. Politics can then be thought of as a balancing of positions until a (temporary) equilibrium is reached. But if there is disagreement about the very dimensions of disagreement – as happens in cases of ideological conflict – such political mechanisms no longer work. The theory and practice of social psychological attitude scaling has political implications that should not be overlooked. It is hard to accept as purely accidental the extraordinary consonance between the social psychological deployment of the category of ‘social attitudes’ and the socio-political culture in which this deployment has flourished. What seems more likely is that this category, like other psychological categories, has always been deeply embedded in a very specific historical assembly of cultural understandings and social practices.

Notes

1. *Psychological* social psychology is distinct from *sociological* social psychology, a branch of the discipline of sociology. Between Allport’s delineation of the field of social psychology and later American psychological texts there is a continuity which does not exist for earlier attempts, like those of McDougall (1908), or Ross (1908). See also Post (1980).

2. Strictly speaking, this is only true of English-language psychology, and even here there are rare exceptions (e.g. Allport and Vernon, 1933). In Germany, the psychology of expression flourished until the early part of the post-World War II period. English-language references to this curious phenomenon are almost non-existent, but see Asendorpf and Wallbott (1982).

3. Many other examples are to be found in the papers by Messer (1906), and Bühler (1907–8). Quite a detailed and accurate English-language account of these experiments is given in Humphrey (1951). Important parts of Messer’s paper, as well as the previously cited paper by Mayer and Orth (1901) are available in English translation in Mandler and Mandler (1964). See also Titchener (1909).

4. Research on this topic provides an excellent illustration of the marked tendency, within twentieth-century Psychology, to treat conceptual questions as though they were empirical questions (see Smedslund, 1991). The nature and degree of relationship between ‘attitude’ and ‘behaviour’ will obviously depend on how these categories are defined, and that depends, not on some external given, but on us.

5. Rose (1990) interprets this trend in terms of the Foucauldian category of ‘governmentality’.

6. Ranking items on any kind of dimension would not supply this knowledge, because it is possible that several subjects may construct the same rank order, but for different reasons. Thurstone (1959: 237) had been very clear about the foundation of attitude scaling: ‘the separations between the statements in the [attitude] scale may be ascertained by psychophysical principles on the common assumption that equally often noticed differences are equal.’ At no point did he seem to notice that ‘equally often noticed’ by many individuals might not permit the same inference as ‘equally often noticed’ by one individual on different occasions. The unproblematic equation of psychophysical and social judgement was facilitated by seeing both in stimulus–response terms. Judgements were

reduced to automatic and reactive acts of 'noticing'. This excised the meaning-conferring, socially constructive, aspect of the sociological attitude-value scheme of Thomas and Znaniecki (Wiley, 1986).

7. The Gestalt psychological characterization of attitudes as 'forces' in a phenomenal field (Koffka, 1935) also points vaguely in the same direction, though the social dimension was only added later (Asch, 1952).

METALANGUAGE: THE TECHNOLOGICAL FRAMEWORK

In the sphere of scientific activity there are profound affinities between language and method. Both are ways of constituting specific fields of investigative and controlling action (Tseëlon, 1991). If it is to qualify as scientific, method must be explicitly described, and this cannot be done without reference to the kinds of things the method is applied to. A scientific method is never just a wordless or signless practice; it is a practice under some description. So the practitioners' understanding of what they are doing is intimately tied up with their understanding of the world in which or to which they are doing it. On the other hand, a language is never just a system of representation; as soon as it is used it becomes a practice. People 'do things with words' (Austin, 1962); in speaking or writing they carry out performances that have significance for their world. So language and method are intimately bound to each other.

That bond may become manifest in a variety of forms. The links between language and method may vary in closeness, and there may be large differences in the relative importance of one or other pole in this relationship. In this chapter I want to explore the historically unique constitution of the language–method bond that occurred during a crucial period in the development of modern Psychology. That involves tracing the most significant steps by which the language of psychological methodology came to provide an overarching categorical framework for representing psychological reality.

Like biology, methodology was the source of a metalanguage applied to already existing psychological categories. A key term in this metalanguage was 'variable'. When they deployed the methodological metalanguage, psychologists were no longer looking at slices of reality called 'motives', 'attitudes' or 'personality' – they were studying 'motivational variables', 'attitudinal variables' or 'personality variables'. The new metalanguage did not replace the older biological framework; it merely added an extra layer of description. That layer, however, came to play a more thoroughly hegemonic role than the older framework ever did. By the 1950s use of the methodological metalanguage had virtually become mandatory in the context of psychological investigation and theorizing.